Chandrasekaran opines that many things could have been handled differently by Mistry. He could have spoken to the shareholders and benefitted from their advice. Chandrasekaran recalls how, as the head of TCS, he would meet Capital, Oppenheimer and Aberdeen, his primary investors, as and when they desired, even though they owned just 0.5 or 1 per cent of TCS's shareholdings. 'If I give them [Capital, Oppenheimer and Aberdeen] three meetings, I should give the Trusts twenty meetings … I'm morally bound to do it,' he feels.

The success of Tata Sons would have been the success of Tata Trusts and its chairman at a personal level as well. Mistry could have benefitted from Ratan becoming the brand ambassador of Tata Sons. 'He was the ambassador of the country,' says Venu Srinivasan. With Ratan's stature both within India and abroad, he could have helped open several doors and resolve several problems. Together, they could have steered the group to an altogether different level. For the first time in the history of the group, Mistry as chairman had the opportunity to obtain the advice and assistance of a former chairman for a long period of time.

Trust Deficit

The trust deficit between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons inevitably strained relations between Ratan and Mistry as well. It led to the new chairman taking unilateral decisions and keeping the Tata Sons board in the dark about some important issues.

Mistry's handling of certain important issues, such as the strategy to be followed in the case of Tata Steel's loss-making UK segment, became particularly contentious. Differences of perception also arose on how to handle the Tata Docomo issue, Tata Power's Indonesian mines, the future of the Nano, and some Indian Hotels assets bought in India and abroad, which were sold at a loss. The composition and functioning of the General Executive Council (GEC) created by Mistry further widened the chasm.

In the case of Tata Steel UK, Ratan was consternated by the fact that a decision to sell parts of its operations was taken 'without consulting the Tata Sons board and the Trusts'. It was not about the decision as much as about the process.

Tata Trusts had strong views on the subject and taking a decision without so much as consulting the holding company's board was a clear breach of